

Choosing the Right Software System for Your Design Business





Introduction

For many designers, growth isn't just about doing more of the work you want—it's about managing it profitably, and with ease. As business expands, complexity ramps up. More projects in motion. More decisions. More moving parts to coordinate. And more responsibility to keep everything aligned.

The design studios that scale successfully don't add more tools to handle that complexity. Instead, they run the business from one system instead of five—or as many as 14, according to our research¹. That frees owners up for other priorities, from marketing to strategy to family, and leads to smoother projects, clearer numbers, a better experience for clients and teams, and more time for the design work they love.

It's why more designers are moving to the all-in-one software system Houzz Pro—bringing planning, design, financial management, project management, and client communication into one place.



“Houzz Pro is my business partner for running an effective, scalable, healthy business. I feel so grateful that I have a tool I can rely on daily with the team. It's a tool that as a business I can't live without.”

Ann Lopez, Owner & Creative Director, Studio 790 | [Full Case Study](#)

Whether you're already using software to manage your design business, or just beginning to explore your options, use this guide as a quick check: **Is your software helping your business run better - or just giving you more to manage?**

¹2026 U.S. Houzz State of the Industry

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Why Designers are Rethinking Technology

Over time, most designers have steadily added different task-specific tools to run their business. One app for proposals, another for time tracking, another for selections... Now AI tools are being added to the stack, too. But for designers who want to scale successfully, disconnected tools are slowing them down.

Instead of making the business easier to run, the growing stack of software has made it more complicated. Teams are juggling multiple tools that don't talk to each other—and paying for each one of them. The result? Re-entering the same information over and over, tracking down approvals and payments, and piecing together numbers to understand where the business stands. And it's not just one project—across multiple projects each at different stages, that complexity compounds fast.

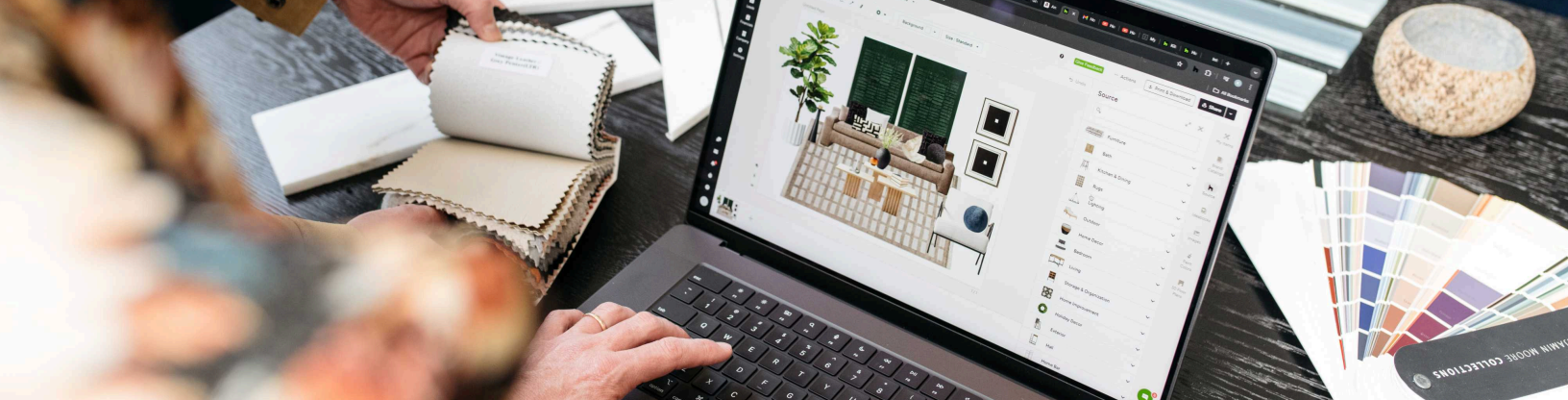
That's what we call Software Overload Syndrome (SOS): entering the same information in multiple places, chasing updates, and never fully trusting the numbers because data lives in different systems.

This isn't about being bad with tech. It's a systems issue. When information is scattered, mistakes slip through, profitability is harder to track, and coordination gets tougher as the business grows.

The fix isn't more software—it's one connected system that:

- Frees you from re-entering information across tools
- Gives you clear, real-time numbers
- Keeps everyone working from the same information
- Supports a seamless, polished client experience from first concept to install
- Holds up as you take on more projects and grow your team
- Uses AI to save time and surface insights while keeping your data secure

Use the checklist ahead as a quick check: Is your software helping you grow, or just giving you more to manage?



6 Questions Every Designer Should Ask About Software

Whether you're looking at software for the first time, questioning the value of what you're using today, or frustrated by how many tools you're managing (and paying for), use this checklist to see if it's moving your business forward—or just creating more work.



“We used to have spreadsheets, emails, and notes everywhere — and keeping track of what was approved, ordered, and paid was getting impossible. Now everything is in Houzz Pro and everything is connected.”

Design by the Jonathans | [Full Case Study](#)

1. Does this software help me reduce repetitive work and keep projects moving?

The goal isn't just organization—it's avoiding the constant re-entry of project details across spreadsheets, Slides, Canva, emails, and purchase orders. This repetition slows down proposals, pulls focus away from design work, and makes it harder to keep projects moving. What to look for:

- ☐ AI-powered 3D models and renderings that convert into proposals
- ☐ Polished, branded proposals that clearly outline scope, pricing, and product details
- ☐ Capture product specs once and use them across the project without retyping
- ☐ Products, specs, and visuals organized in one place for client presentations



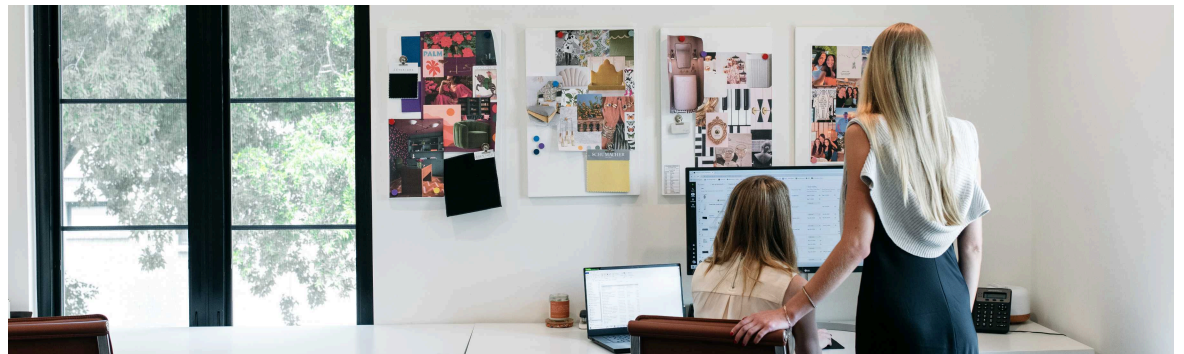
“The budget tool allows the studio to manage the project budget with total transparency. The client is going to trust you more because you’re managing their money better.”

Studio 790 Interior Design | [Full Case Study](#)

2. Does this software help me know my numbers on every project?

You shouldn’t have to spend weekends piecing together numbers in spreadsheets just to see if you’re making money on a project. What to look for:

- ☐ Proposals and invoicing with markup, and sales tax built in
- ☐ Online payment processing to collect and track payments on projects
- ☐ Simple time tracking tools connected to billing and reporting
- ☐ Real-time visibility into what’s been paid, what’s outstanding, and what’s committed
- ☐ Financial integration with accounting tools like QuickBooks Online and Gusto



3. Can my team run projects without chasing information?

When everyone’s working from the same system, projects move faster, mistakes are avoided, and the team stays aligned without constant follow-up. What to look for:

- ☐ Team and client texts, emails, and messages in one place
- ☐ Document management with the latest version always at hand
- ☐ The ability to keep track of every order, from status to financial details
- ☐ Mobile-friendly tools that allow access to the latest project information on site

4. Does this software help me deliver a seamless, polished client experience from first concept to final payment?

Your reputation isn't just about the finished project—it's shaped by how the project runs. You put a lot of effort into clear client communication, timely updates, and a process that feels as organized and polished as your brand. What to look for:

- ☐ One source of truth for client communication and approvals
- ☐ Comprehensive selection tools to track options, decisions, and orders
- ☐ Online payment processing tools
- ☐ Polished, branded proposals, mood boards, and client communications.



“Keeping track from team member to team member is really important. Having those live updates — where everyone has access to the same information — is very helpful. Everything is in Houzz Pro and everything is connected.”

Design by the Jonathans | [Full Case Study](#)





“I think Houzz has given us confidence that we are presenting a consistent experience for our clients. The experience is really what people are buying, and with Houzz Pro, they’re enjoying going through decision-making including selections.”

Bex Interiors | [Full Case Study](#)

5. Will this system hold up as we’re running more projects — or growing the team?

When projects multiply or your team grows, your software should scale with you—giving your team room to take ownership while still maintaining your standards.

What to look for:

- ☐ Easy-to-learn tools that teams can start using quickly
- ☐ Customizable templates that create repeatable processes
- ☐ Standardized workflows that maintain consistency across projects
- ☐ Email templates with AI-generated drafts for faster, professional client messaging



“It’s seamless, we’re no longer bouncing between systems. Houzz Pro automates our workflows and makes it easier to scale our business while maintaining consistency.”

Etch Design Group | [Full Case Study](#)

6. Is this software using AI to help us move faster—while keeping data secure?

The right technology shouldn’t just store information. It should cut admin, speed communication, and surface insights—all within a secure system that protects your data. What to look for:

- ☐ AI built specifically for designer workflows
- ☐ Automation that reduces admin and speeds communication
- ☐ AI that surfaces insights across your business
- ☐ High security and data privacy standards, with data never used to train public AI

Why Simplified Software Wins (And Actually Gets Used)

Growth doesn't come from adding more software. It comes from choosing the right system your team will actually use every day.

Houzz Pro is built to be easy to adopt from day one. When software is easy to use, information stays accurate, teams stay aligned, and projects run with fewer surprises.



And when your system is built the right way, it should take work off your plate, too. Houzz Pro's AI is built differently. Designed for the industry, it works across your client, design, and procurement workflows instead of sitting in a silo. It helps draft client updates, handles repetitive tasks behind the scenes, and surfaces insights about your business in one secure place. So you can spend less time on admin and more time designing and taking care of clients.

After everything in this guide, one question matters most: **Will my team actually use this every day?**

If the answer isn't a clear yes, no feature list will fix that. Choose one system your whole team trusts—and make it the operational backbone of the business.



What This Looks Like in a Real Business

Design Studios like Etch Design Group have already made this shift—moving from juggling 5+ tools to running their entire studio in Houzz Pro, one software system that can do it all.

The result: less complexity, more control, and a smoother client experience at every stage of the project.

Proof in practice:

30-35

hours/week saved through
automation and centralized workflows



10-20%

annual cost savings by reducing
manual admin



50-60

active projects managed with clear
visibility from start to finish



It's not just about whether your design business is ready to scale. It's about whether your software is built to scale with you.

Let us show you how Houzz Pro can support your business.

[Book a Personalized Demo](#)